

IS 2012 END OF THE WORLD?

Now we all have been exposed to this myth or as some want to call it a prophecy that the world will end in 2012.

From the Mayan civilisation to pessimistic hobos everyone has been taken by its fancy. But what do anthropologists make of it? Find out more <http://bit.ly/nMlc6y>

SOFTWARE IS EATING THE WORLD!

If this sounds bizarre, then the recent developments in the tech world should be taken into consideration. Google buys Motorola, HP discontinues webOS. Both earth-shattering announcements, but how does it connect to the title? Find out on <http://on.wsj.com/o6yleE>

SCIENCE OF SMILES

Ever wondered what's behind a person's smile? In this detailed interview with Yale's psychology professor, the author tries to breakdown the very nature of smiling. Get to know what lies beneath that smile. An interesting read at <http://bit.ly/pQ138V>

GORY DEATHS IN PC GAMES

Don't we all love when the protagonist in an action game rips the enemy's guts out? Here's a great round up of 25 videos featuring some of the most gruesome deaths in PC games. Things might get unpleasant! Don't say we didn't warn you. Here's the link to go to <http://bit.ly/oySU2B>

Berger's upcoming paper goes further, however, suggesting that readers value and share hope and awe, but that they'll share content that makes them anxious and angry as well. The paper was co-authored by Katherine L. Milkman, an assistant professor of operations and information management at Wharton.

The study examined more than 7,000 New York Times articles over a three-month period to discover why they made the "most emailed" list. It tried to eliminate other sources of influence, such as the time of the day when the story was published, in which section it appeared, its topic, the popularity and gender of the author, and other factors.

Arousal, Berger and Milkman concluded, provokes; it prompts users to act. Anger, the most provocative negative response, also spurs action, while sadness

What does that mean? Awe-inspiring headlines included "Rare Treatment Is Reported to Cure AIDS Patient" and "The Promise and Power of RNA". Anxiety-inducing headlines included "For Stocks, Worst Single-Day Drop in Two Decades". Feel-good stories also did well, including "Wide-Eyed New Arrivals Falling in Love With the City". And "What Red Ink? Wall Street Paid Hefty Bonuses" provoked anger, and emails.

Interestingly, the authors found that a one-standard-deviation increase in the amount of anger provoked by an article upped the chances of being in the most-emailed list by 34 percent, or the equivalent of an additional 2.9 hours on the site's front page.

Berger and Milkman also tested their theory; the researchers dummied up a pair of ad campaigns, based on the premise that sausage maker Jimmy Dean had hired either a farmer or a rabbi as its new spokesman. Not surprisingly, the fact that pork products are not considered kosher in the Jewish faith amused most of the survey respondents,

and they said they were more likely to share the news. They also asked the survey respondents which headline they would be most likely to share: one that said an airline "breaks" guitars, or one that reported



Popular blog theoatmeal.com

that the airline "smashes" guitars. Again, unsurprisingly, most chose the latter.

Interestingly, however, a third experiment proved that sadness can be a demotivating factor. When asked whether they would be likely to share about a woman's recovery (one version of the story used 9/11 as an excuse; the other, a fall down stairs) the respondents chose to share the second version more.

The study measured emailed stories, however, and not sharing of content on Twitter, Facebook, or blogs. But the study found the two overlap, with one exception.

"Analysis suggests that similar factors drive both virality and blogging: more emotional, positive, interesting, and anger-inducing, and less sadness-inducing stories are more likely to make the most blogged list," the study found. "Interestingly, the effect of practical utility reverses – though a practically useful story is more likely to make the most emailed list, practically useful content is marginally less likely to be blogged about. This may be due in part to the nature of blogs as commentary."



Classic example of a viral video 'David after dentist'

is a passive response, and generally does not result in content being shared. However, the most high-arousal, positive emotion is awe, meaning that awe-inspiring or, literally, "awesome" content is most often shared.